

Fig. 10.9: Relic box from the Vaishali stupa (now in the Patna Museum)

This, of course, invites speculation on whether the event described in Buddhist texts is the one detectable at Vaishali. An intentional breach is clearly discernible but why it was made is not. Theoretically, there are many possibilities, including mischief by miscreants in unsettled times and desecration by a rival religious group. Their likelihood, though, is weakened by the casket having been reinterred inside the stupa rather than removed from it, which then raises the plausibility of the hypothesis that the breach was caused in order to remove a portion of the relics, perhaps by Ashoka as the literature asserts. If so, Ashoka was expanding not just the monumentality of these sites but also future perceptions of their degree of sacredness, an imaginative innovation towards altering the dimensions of pre-existing religiosity. The proliferation of stupas beyond North India seems to have been at least partly a result of this innovation.